

Evaluation 4 : The Laws of UX

LIS 636 - Website Production and Usability for Librarians

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I. Site Overview

For this evaluation, I am looking at the Cumberland County Public Library website. This site is part of the larger Cumberland County government website, but the library page is meant to help users find library services and resources. Some users may come to the site to search the library catalog, check their account, find library locations, get a library card, look for children's resources, find events, or use online research tools.

The feature I chose to analyze is the quick-link section on the library homepage. This section includes important links such as Catalog / My Account, Calendar, Resources & Research, Locations, Get a Library Card, Local History, Kids, Using the Library, Reader's Corner, and Submit Feedback. These links are listed near the main library heading, before the news and contact information sections. I chose this feature because it works like the main starting point for users. Instead of reading the whole page, users can click one of these links and go directly to the service they need.

I will use Hick's Law to evaluate this feature. Hick's Law is a good fit because the quick-link section gives users several choices at once. The links are helpful, but the number of choices may also make the page feel a little overwhelming, especially for someone who is visiting the site for the first time.

II. Literature Review

Hick's Law explains that decision time increases as the number and complexity of choices grow (Yablonski, n.d.). In simple terms, more options can slow users down or make them unsure of what to click. This matters for website design because users usually arrive with a specific goal, and too many choices can make that goal harder to complete.

The idea comes from psychology research on reaction time. Hick (1952) and Hyman (1953) found that response time increases with the amount of information involved in a decision. Although their studies were not about websites, the concept applies to UX design because users must choose between links, menus, and tools.

UX sources recommend limiting choices, organizing information clearly, and breaking tasks into smaller steps (Interaction Design Foundation, 2020; Sherwin, 2018; Yablonski, n.d.). Too many options can lead to confusion or "choice overload," where users struggle to decide at all (Iyengar & Lepper, 2000). This is especially important for library websites, which offer many services. The goal is not to remove options, but to organize them so users can make decisions more easily.

Grant (2022) also supports this idea in 101 UX Principles. One of his navigation principles is to split menu items into subsections so users do not have to remember large lists. This connects well to Hick's Law because grouping related options can make a long list feel easier to understand. Instead of showing many choices all at once, a website can divide them into smaller sections so users can scan the page faster and decide where to click.

Overall, Hick's Law helps evaluate whether the number and organization of choices on the Cumberland County Public Library website make it easier or harder for users to find what they need.

III. Feature Analysis

The quick-link section on the Cumberland County Public Library website has several strengths. It gives users direct access to common tasks like searching the catalog, checking the calendar, finding locations, or getting a library card. Clear links such as “Catalog / My Account,” “Calendar,” “Locations,” “Get a Library Card,” and “Kids” are easy to understand and help users make quick decisions, which supports Hick’s Law.

However, there are also some issues. The section includes many links at once, and not all are equally clear. Links like “Resources & Research,” “Using the Library,” and “Reader’s Corner” may require more thought, especially for first-time users. This can slow decision-making and make the page feel overwhelming.

This is where Grant’s idea about splitting menu items into smaller subsections would be helpful. The library website already provides useful links, but the links could be organized more clearly by function. For example, categories like “Find Materials,” “Visit the Library,” “Library Help,” and “For Families” would make the page easier to scan. This would reduce choice overload and better support Hick’s Law by breaking decisions into simpler steps.

IV. Conclusion and Recommendations

Using Hick's Law, I think the Cumberland County Public Library website does a good job giving users access to important library services, but the quick-link section could be improved. The section is useful because it places many common tasks in one area. Users can quickly find links for the catalog, calendar, locations, library cards, and children's resources. This is helpful and should not be removed.

My main recommendation is to organize the quick links into smaller groups. This would make the page easier to scan and reduce the feeling of having too many choices at once. I would also recommend adding short descriptions for links that may not be clear to first-time users. For example, under "Resources & Research," the site could briefly mention databases, research tools, or online resources. Under "Reader's Corner," the site could mention book recommendations or reading lists.

Overall, the quick-link section is a strong feature, but Hick's Law shows that the site could make user decisions easier by grouping choices and making broad labels more specific. These changes would help users find what they need faster and make the library website feel less overwhelming.

V. Screenshot Illustrations

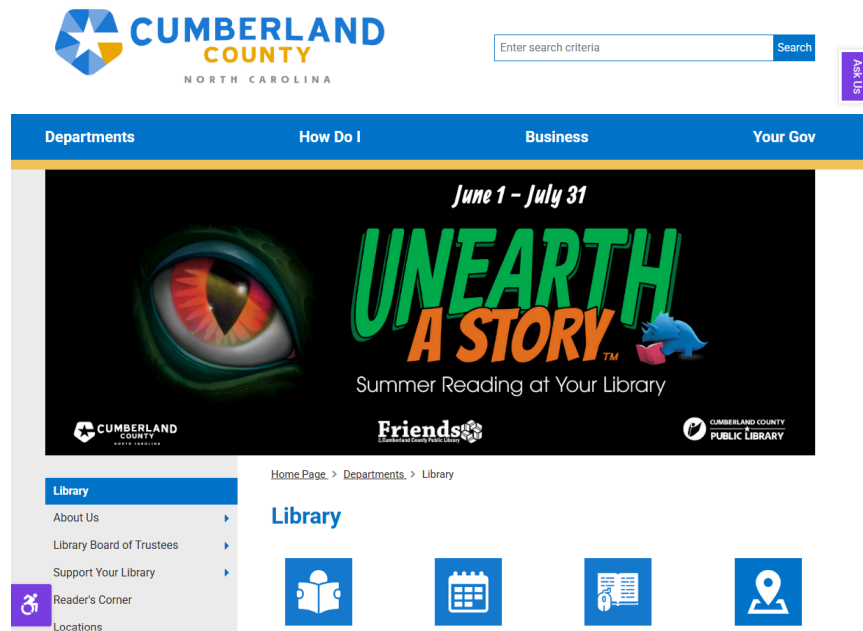


Figure 1. Cumberland County Public Library homepage showing the main page layout, banner, side menu, and beginning of the quick-link section.

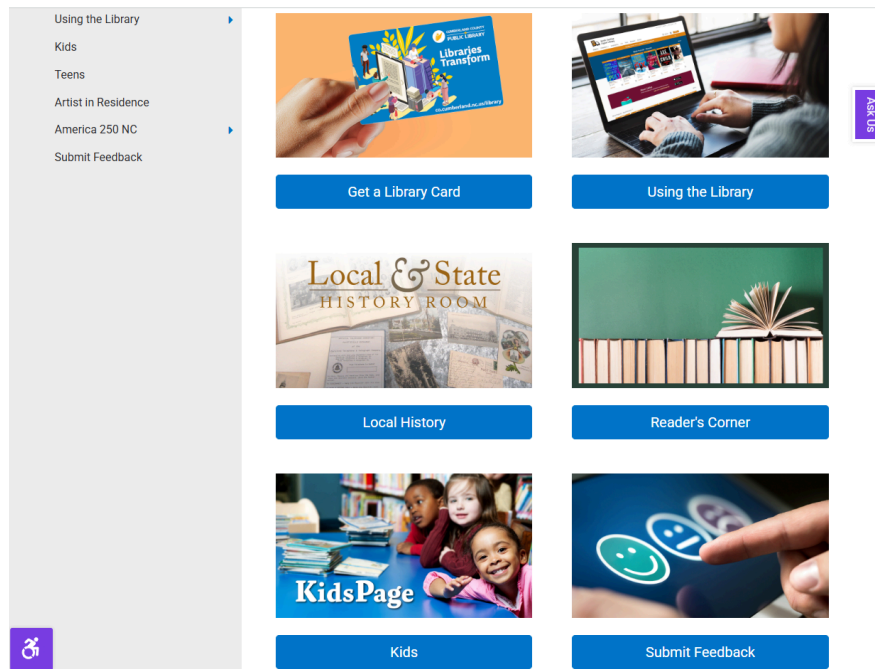


Figure 2. Quick-link section showing several library service options presented together.

VI. References

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